Secrets of the Sword

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25116625.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Gen

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Darla | Mara's Ship (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela, Man-At-Arms (He-Man), Battle Cat | Cringer, Evil-Lyn (He-Man), Skeletor (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Beastman (He-Man), Tri-Klops (He-Man), Sorceress of Castle Grayskull | Zoar the Falcon, Mara (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Gwildor

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Honor & Power

Stats:
Published: 2020-07-06 Completed: 2020-08-04 Words: 18,096 Chapters: 10/10

Secrets of the Sword

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25116625.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Gen

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), He-Man and the Masters of the Universe

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Darla | Mara's Ship (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela, Man-At-Arms (He-Man), Battle Cat | Cringer, Evil-Lyn (He-Man), Skeletor (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man), Beastman (He-Man), Tri-Klops (He-Man), Sorceress of Castle Grayskull | Zoar the Falcon, Mara (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra), Gwildor

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Honor & Power

Stats:
Published: 2020-07-06 Completed: 2020-08-04 Words: 18,096
Chapters: 10/10

Secrets of the Sword

by inkpenavenger

Summary

As the Best Friend Squad explores and returns magic to the universe, Adora can't help but be haunted by what Horde Prime once said of her people - "I thought the First Ones were all gone, but clearly some faction remains" - With countless planets in the universe, surely the one Adora was stolen from is out there somewhere...
=======
Now complete!

Post-script interludes
Sequel: Master of the Universe

Notes

I'm not super up on the community lingo, so if there's any tags you all think should be added, let me know.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Adora couldn't sleep. She stared up at the ceiling of the darkened room. The only sounds out here in deep space were the hum of Darla's engines and the soft breathing of Catra, fast asleep beside her.

Adora swung her legs off the edge of the bed, getting up as carefully as she could to avoid waking Catra. She left the room, padding into the ship's main corridor. From the front of the ship, she could hear Entrapta talking to herself, or rather into her recorder, about whatever aspects of Darla's performance she was fixated on at the moment. Adora turned instead to the rear of the ship, toward the cargo hold.

The only light as Adora entered the hold was the dim, color-shifting glow of the artificial runestone. Entrapta and Hordak had constructed it to carry magical energy from Etheria to be used to kick-start the natural magic of any worlds they found where it lay dormant. Adora sat on one of the nearby crates containing a portal beacon, another device Entrapta and Hordak had whipped up that allowed Darla to teleport instantly between Etheria and any friendly planets where they set one up, and lost herself in thought, staring vacantly at the runestone and feeling the magic radiating from it.

The adventures in space had already been many. The Best Friends Squad had restored magic to several worlds, made friends on several more, and had many battles with strange creatures, hostile aliens, and space pirates. Through all of it, a long unanswered question had begun nagging at Adora's mind, something she'd written off as irrelevant, but as time went on, she found it occupying her thoughts more and more…

I thought the First Ones were all gone, but clearly some faction remains…

"Hey, Adora," Catra's voice pulled Adora from her reverie.

"Catra?" she said. "I'm sorry, I tried not to wake you…"

"You didn't," Catra replied. She crossed the room and sat down on the crate next to Adora. “What are you doing in here, anyway?”

“I couldn’t sleep,” Adora confessed.

“Obviously,” Catra said with a smirk as she slipped her arm around Adora’s waist. “So what’s bothering you?”

Adora looked back up at the runestone’s glow, considering how to put it into words.

“Do you ever think about where we came from?” she said at last. “You know, before the Horde?”

“Not really, no,” Catra replied. “I mean, I don’t really remember anything before the Fright Zone. It never really mattered to me, I guess.”

“I guess it didn’t matter to me either for a long time, but…”

“But now it does?”

Adora nodded.

“I told you about how Light Hope kidnapped me,” Adora continued, “about how she used Hordak’s portal to bring me to Etheria.”

Catra nodded.

“Well, I can’t help but wonder, now that we’re out exploring the universe, if the people she took me from are still out there somewhere. If they are, I’d like to know who they are and to let them know that I’m safe,” Adora took Catra’s hand in hers. “That I’m happy.”

They sat there in the dark for a moment, Catra running her thumb over Adora’s knuckles. At last, Catra reached up and turned

Adora's face to look at her.

"Hey," she smiled, "then we'll find them.

"How?" Adora asked, though unable to stop herself smiling back. "There are so many worlds out here. It'll be like looking for a needle in the world's biggest haystack."

"Entrapta," Catra said after a moment's thought. "I'll bet she can find something in this ship's old databanks. Or maybe the Horde had information that could point us in the right direction." She shrugged, "At least maybe we can narrow it down?"

"That's a great idea! Adora exclaimed. She pulled Catra into a tight hug. "Thank you for understanding."

"Of course," Catra said. "You want to find out where you came from, then we'll find where you came from. Together."

"I love you," said Adora with a warm smile.

Catra kissed her.

"I love you, too."

They sat in the hold a while longer, Adora resting her head on Catra's shoulder, until Adora's eyes finally grew heavy, and at last they went back to bed.

=======

"I thought you'd *never* ask!" Entrapta cried.

Everyone blinked at her for a moment. Adora had brought up the idea of looking for her homeworld once she, Catra, Entrapta, Glimmer, and Bow had all met in the kitchen that morning while Wrong Hordak busied himself preparing breakfast.

“Wait, what?” asked Glimmer.

“I’ve been cross-referencing Horde Prime’s star charts with those I’d salvaged from First Ones databanks for *months!* ” Entrapta explained, excitedly.

“Why didn’t you say anything before now?” Catra asked.

“I...” Entrapta stopped short. “I thought the whole being-kidnapped thing might be a painful subject for Adora, so I didn’t want to say anything unless she asked. Did I...get that wrong?”

“No, no, it’s fine,” Adora said. “Did you find anything?”

“ *Did I!?* ” Entrapta sprang from her seat, sweeping the scattering of dishes from the table with her hair and quickly setting up a hologram projector. “The information from the First Ones’ ruins on Etheria is degraded and incomplete, not to mention a thousand years out of date, so the first step was to figure out reference points to align Prime’s star charts with those of the First Ones.”

The projector filled the space above the table with countless tiny pinpricks of light: a representation of the galaxy. Some of the dots were green while others were pink. As Entrapta continued, the pink dots shifted to align with the green, turning yellow on contact.

“Once I had the star charts synced, then came the tricky part! I had to look for things that *weren’t* in the Horde’s files. Obviously, Adora was born on a First Ones colony world that Prime didn’t know about or else he would have attacked and destroyed it years ago. So after controlling for all the variables I could, I was left with...one!”

The display zoomed in on a single point of light, the only one that remained pink. First Ones text appeared beside it.

“The First Ones called this planet-” Entrapta began.

“Eternia,” Adora read. She stood up, “That has to be it! ‘Eternia’ was the password to get into the Crystal Castle!”

“Adora, we can’t know that for sure,” Bow said.

“But Bow,” said Glimmer, “it’s a planet the First Ones knew about that Horde Prime didn’t. That’s got to mean something.”

“Even if it’s not the right place,” said Catra, “it’s obviously connected to Adora’s people. And it’s our only lead, so I say it’s worth a shot.”

Adora looked around the table, smiling at the excitement and support of her friends.

“Alright,” Bow said with a grin, “then let’s do this!”

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A few days later, Darla was finally on approach to the planet the First Ones' database called Eternia. Adora had been growing increasingly anxious as the planet had grown closer day by day. A fact that had not escaped the notice of her friends.

"It'll be ok, Adora," Glimmer had said. "Even if this isn't the right place, maybe we'll find some clue that'll lead us there."

"And if it's not the right place," Bow had added, "we'll keep looking until we find it."

"And think of all the *data* we could recover even from an *abandoned* First Ones colony!" Entrapta had chimed in with a characteristic maniacal giggle.

Adora was grateful for their support, she really was. But nervous thoughts still raced around her head. What if they arrived at Eternia and there was nothing there? What if whatever had been there was long since destroyed? What if it wasn't the right place at all? What if the people there held no more answers than she had right now?

What if there was never anyone there who cared about her at all?

"Hey," Catra said, standing beside Adora holding her hand as the planet grew steadily larger in the ship's canopy window, "it's gonna be ok."

Adora smiled and squeezed Catra's hand. Melog padded up and nuzzled Adora's other hand.

"Darla's sensors are definitely picking up signs of life," Entrapta said as they approached. "And civilization! No mistaking those

energy readings."

"So whatever else this place is, there's at least *people* here," Glimmer said. "That's something, at least."

"Entrapta," Bow said from the pilot seat, "help guide me in away from any settlements. Don't want to spook anyone. We should probably cloak the rest of the way in, too."

Melog mewled an acknowledgement and began to glow. Soon, the ship filled with drifting motes of light and vanished from sight to the outside world. The ship entered the atmosphere and sailed over the landscape below. Adora could see dense forests and rolling plains, craggy mountains and winding rivers.

"There," Bow said. "That patch of forest looks like a few hours' walk from one of the bigger cities. We can land there and then start exploring."

The city could be seen in the distance. A walled city built on and around a hill with an ornate stone castle at the heart of it. Bow spotted a clearing in the forest and gently set the ship down. Melog dropped its invisibility field.

"Exploring an alien world with no signs of extraplanetary contact in hundreds of years," Entrapta cried, gathering up tool and instruments. "This is *so exciting!* "

"You ready, Adora?" Glimmer asked.

"No," she replied. "Let's go."

Catra gave Adora's hand a reassuring squeeze, and they all made their way to the entry ramp. As soon as they stepped outside, Adora was hit with an inexplicable sensation of familiarity.

"Woah," said Glimmer. "Do you feel that?" She traced a quick spell glyph in the air. "This planet *definitely* has magic."

"Yeah," Adora replied. That was probably it; she was just feeling the planet's magic.

Suddenly, a figure burst out of the treeline.

"Hold it," the stranger said. "Who are you? Why are you here?"

The stranger was a man, tall, older, with hair going gray at the temples and a thick brown mustache. He was decked out in green armor with a yellow sash, and his right arm appeared to be mechanical. In that hand, he held what was clearly a weapon, not dissimilar to the Horde's stun blasters.

"Woah! Hey! Don't shoot!" Glimmer cried. She, Bow, Adora, and Catra raised their empty hands. Entrapta raised her pigtails.

"Who are you?" the man again demanded. "What is this... *thing* ?" He gestured at the ship with his weapon.

"I...we...well…" Adora stammered. Then another figure emerged from the forest, this one a young woman.

"I *knew* I felt something!" she cried. She had chin-length red hair and green eyes, wore plain clothes, and carried a staff. She stared wide-eyed at the ship looming above them all.

"Adam!" she called over her shoulder back into the forest. "You've *got* to see this!"

"We're coming!" another voice called from among the trees. Then a young man appeared, who seemed to be pushing/dragging a large, green, feline creature along with him. "C'mon, Cringer," he implored it, "there's nothing to be afraid of." He had short blonde hair that spiked up in the front and blue eyes. He wore a red vest over a white shirt and dark pants. He had a silver-handled sword slung over his back.

"Yeah, Dad," the young woman added. "Put the gun away, they don't look hostile."

“They haven’t answered my question yet,” the man said with a wary scowl.

“My name’s Adora,” Adora blurted, “and this is Catra, Bow, Glimmer, Entrapta, and Melog.” She gestured to each in turn as she spoke. “And there’s one other still inside. We’re-”

“Visitors from another world?” said the young man with obvious excitement. “I knew it! Teela, that thing they came in looks just like the murals in the Castle.”

“Yeah it does,” the young woman replied in wonder. “You were right.”

“Another world,” the older man scoffed. “Ridiculous.”

“It’s true!” Entrapta interjected. “And there’s not just our world, but countless others.”

The older man regarded them all with clear mistrust.

“Come on, Duncan,” the young man said. “They answered your questions, didn’t they? Put the gun away.”

“Fine,” the man said. “But I’ve got my eyes on you…” He lowered and stowed the weapon in a hip holster.

Adora and the others finally lowered their hands.

“I’m Adam,” the young man said, extending his hand in greeting. Adora took it. “This is my friend Teela, and her father, Duncan. The big scaredy cat back there is Cringer.”

The big green cat cowered in the underbrush near the treeline. Melog suddenly appeared in front of him, having slipped away without anyone noticing. Cringer pressed himself flat to the ground and covered his eyes with his front paws. Melog mewed at him in confusion.

“Cringer, for crying out loud they’re not going to hurt you!” Adam said, shaking his head. “So you’re really from another world?”

“Yes,” said Glimmer. “It’s...kind of a long story.”

“Like, *really* long,” Bow added.

“Well join us for lunch and you can explain,” Teela said.

“We’re *supposed* to be on patrol,” said Duncan sternly.

“Yeah well, it’s midday, so it’s time to stop for lunch anyway, right?” countered Adam.

Before he could continue, there was a crashing sound of splintering wood from the other side of the clearing. Suddenly smashing through the trees and into the open was a nearly twenty foot tall humanoid creature that appeared to be made of living stone.

“What in the world is that thing?” Catra cried, reflexively extending her claws. Melog’s mane turned spiky and red as it quickly loped back to her side.

“Another of Skeletor’s rock monsters!” Duncan shouted. He drew his weapon again.

The creature roared and began stomping toward them. Adora reached out her hand, the air beginning to shimmer before her.

“Look out!” Adam called, suddenly darting out between everyone else and the monster. He drew the sword from his back, which had a very familiar-looking crystalline blade, and held it in the air.

“By the power of Grayskull!”

Energy arced around the sword, and there was a bright flash of light. A moment later and Adam was gone. In his place stood a nearly eight-foot-tall lean and muscular man with messy, shoulder

length blonde hair. He wore a black crop top and pants with heavy boots and a gold-colored armored harness and bracers.

“Wait, what?” Adora stammered, her eyes wide.

Adam raced toward the monster, dodging a heavy blow from its fist that left a three-foot-deep hole in the ground. He darted between its legs and turned to leap straight up above its head. He brought his sword down with a yell and cleaved the creature clean in two. The bisected halves of the monster crumbled apart and stopped moving.

Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Catra all exchanged astonished, wide-eyed glances with each other.

Adam walked calmly back over to the others, transforming back to his original form and sheathing the sword once more on his back.

“So,” he said casually, “lunch?”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! My take on He-Man's look is inspired by some great fan art I stumbled upon a while ago. https://tinyurl.com/ydytjnml (Took me a while to track down the original source of the images. Artist has lots of great stuff.)
Anyway, I hope you enjoyed the story so far, and I look forward to keeping it going and giving my answers as to what the heck is going on here!
Thanks again!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The silence was shattered by Entrapta's sudden squeal of delight. In an instant she'd carried herself over to Adam on her hair and was poking, prodding, and examining him.

"Where did you get that sword can I examine it it looks like First Ones' tech is it First Ones' tech do you know anything about the First Ones on this planet can I take tissue samples?" she yammered.

"Can you what? Ow!" Adam said as Entrapta plucked one of his hairs and fed it into a compartment on her tracker pad.

"How… how did you do that?" Adora said.

"Adam," Duncan scolded, "did you really think it was a good idea revealing yourself like that in front of complete strangers?"

"What?" replied Adam, defensively. "They're not even from this planet. Who are they going to tell? It's not like my parents will find out from *them.* "

Duncan scowled with disapproval.

"Actually, I think he's right this time, Adam," added Teela. "You should be more careful about who sees you transform into… y'know."

"Everybody back up," Catra suddenly demanded. She had stepped closer to Adora and had a defensive hand on her shoulder. "Who *are* you guys, really? And how did blondie here turn into a boy She-Ra?"

"She-Ra?" Adam said in confusion as Entrapta kept trying to lift and examine his arms.

"Ok, let's all just calm down," Glimmer interrupted. "Entrapta, stop poking Adam." Entrapta complied reluctantly. "Now lets just all start from the beginning." Glimmer took a deep breath and stood up straighter.

"I am Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon from the planet Etheria," she began. "We are on a mission to restore magic to planets that had theirs stolen by the First Ones empire and to offer aid to worlds rebuilding in the wake of the fall of the Galactic Horde."

"Then…" Adam began, a little sheepishly, "you probably ought to meet with my parents. I'm… sort of… the *prince* of Eternia."

"Now wait a minute," Duncan said. "What's all this about First Ones and Hordes?"

"The First Ones were an interplanetary civilization that colonized many, many worlds," said Bow, "including ours and, if our information is right, yours."

"But their civilization was wiped out by Horde Prime sometime within the last thousand years," Adora added.

Teela looked thoughtful for a moment.

"Nothing I've ever read in the archives or in the Castle ever indicated any prior alien civilization," she explained. "But like Adam said, we have seen images depicting vessels like yours in the sky. We suspected it meant that our ancient ancestors once travelled to other words." She looked at Adam. "But *she* never gives us a straight answer about that kind of thing."

"This is all very enlightening," said Catra, growing impatient, "but what about him and the sword and the -woosh- muscles?"

"Right," Adam said, drawing the sword again from his back. "This is the Sword of Power, given to me by the Sorceress of Castle

Grayskull. Whoever is chosen to wield it can become He-Man, champion of Eternia and protector of the Castle's secrets."

Adora looked at Catra.

"I was chosen because an evil warlord caled Skeletor wages war on my kingdom," Adam continued. "He seeks to overthrow my father and take the secrets of Grayskull so he can rule our world forever. My… parents don't know that I'm He-Man. Neither do most of the people of Eternia, just Duncan and Teela, and another friend of ours. Oh, and Cringer of course."

"Alright, we've shared plenty with you," said Duncan. "Now what about you? What was this 'She-Ra' you mentioned before?"

"It'll… probably just be easier to show you," Adora said. She took a few steps back from the group, held out her hand, and summoned her sword. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Bright shimmering light filled the clearing, and when it subsided, Adora had transformed. She-Ra now stood wreathed in her multicolored aura of magical light.

"No way!" Adam cried. "I… what… how… Teela?"

"I… don't know," Teela said, dumbfounded. "I've never read anything about another sword or another warrior like He-Man."

"Oooooh I'd *love* to gather data comparing your capabilities," Entrapta crowed. "Can you both transform and perform some experiments?"

"Maybe later," Adora said, changing back to herself.

"For sure," Adam agreed. "For now, you all should definitely meet my parents. And after that, you should probably meet the Sorceress, too, Adora."

"Well if we're heading back, we best get to it," Duncan said. "It's a long walk back to the city."

Melog and Wrong Hordak stayed with the ship so they could hide or move it if need be. Meanwhile, Glimmer, Bow, Adora, Catra, and Entrapta followed Adam, Teela, Duncan, and Cringer out of the forest and onward toward the city.

=======

Far away across a desert wasteland, atop a craggy mountain peak, within a black stone tower around which coiled a great carved serpent, a green-skinned woman waved and curled her long-fingered hands over a pool of brackish liquid. Images shimmered beneath the pool's surface, images of locations within the distant peaceful kingdom that could serve as valuable targets for her master's conquest. Suddenly, the image she was viewing was washed out by a brilliant flash of light. The light poured from the pool, briefly illuminating the dark chamber as though with daylight and stinging the woman's eyes.

After only a moment, as quickly as it appeared, the light subsided. The woman found she had fallen to the floor. She'd never felt such a surge of raw magical power. She sprang to her feet and strode quickly out of her sanctum toward her master's throne room.

"My lord," she called as she opened the great black steel doors and entered the vaulted chamber. "I-"

"Yes, Evil-lyn," the deep raspy voice answered. "I felt it too. Such power!" Her master gazed coldly at her from the empty eye sockets beneath his dark purple cowl. His grip tightened on his ram-headed staff. "We must locate the source of this great power and make it mine."

"Yes, Lord Skeletor."

Chapter End Notes

Dun dun duuuuuuun! Lol

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Bit of a gap since the last chapter. Thanks for your patience and for coming back.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Several hours later, they reached the outer wall of the city. At Duncan's signal, the guards opened the large gates to allow them in. As the massive doors slid open, the Etherians gasped at the sight. A bustling city lay just beyond the gate, bigger and busier than almost anywhere on their home planet. Only in the Fight Zone had Catra and Adora seen so many people living and working so close together. As they made their way up the streets toward the center of town, people who noticed Adam stepped back out of the way to let the group pass, some with a short bow and utterance of "your highness."

Adora marvelled at the sights sounds and smells of the lively city. She hope that if there was time later, she and Catra could go exploring together…

"Wait," said Bow. "Adora, look! All the shops and signs. Everything is in First Ones writing!"

Adora paused, and Bow was right. She hadn't really noticed because, of course, she could read it, but all the text and writing everywhere around them was in the distinct, line-and-shapes First Ones language.

"First Ones," Teela said. "You keep talking about these First Ones. And you say our written language is the same as theirs?"

"Yeah," Adora replied, "but I don't-"

"It's obvious isn't it?" Entrapta said. "The current inhabitants of Eternia are the descendants of the First Ones settlers. They just

must have lost knowledge of their origins over the last thousand years somehow."

Adora started. She looked all around, eyes wide. These people, all of these people, were *her* people. They were all First Ones, just like her. She felt her hand squeezed. She looked to her side to meet Catra's eyes.

"Hey," Catra said, "you ok?"

"I…" Adora began, but she couldn't find words.

"It's a lot," Catra said.

Adora nodded.

"Hey, how about after the important meeting-between-planetary-leaders thing, you and me sneak off to check out the city?"

Adora nodded again. Catra squeezed her hand again, and they kept walking, Adora still trying to stare at everything at once.

=======

It was early evening by the time the group had reached the castle at the center of the city. The guards had let them all in, and they'd been led to a comfortable sitting room while their hosts left to take care of things that needed done. Duncan and Teela had taken off to report in to the other royal guards. Adam had left to tell his parents the king and queen of their guests' arrival.

In the sitting room, Entrapta was walking and climbing about everywhere with her hair, scanning everything she could reach with her tracker pad and giggling in clear delight. Glimmer and Bow sat on a couch together while Catra sat on another, her tail

twitching with mild irritation, as Adora once again paced the room.

"Adora," Catra said, "relax! Come sit down."

"Right, right," Adora said. She made her way over to sit beside Catra, who put an arm around her shoulders, trying to soothe her obvious anxiety.

Adora sat in uncomfortable silence, left leg bouncing rapidly, until moments later she stood up again, prompting an eye-roll and sigh from Catra.

"Should it be taking this long?" she asked, pacing again and speaking very fast. "It feels like it's taking a really long time."

"It's been five minutes," Bow said, exasperated.

"Really? It feels longer. Should I ask what's taking so long? I'm gonna ask what's taking-"

With a groan, Glimmer vanished from her seat, appeared in front of Adora, put her hands on Adora's shoulders, and teleported them both in front of Catra's seat.

"Catra," Glimmer said, pushing Adora down onto the couch, "do *not* let her up again." Then she vanished again and reappeared back next to Bow on the other couch.

"You got it, Sparkles," Catra replied, wrapping both arms around Adora from behind. She rested her chin on Adora's shoulder and whispered to her, "Breathe, Adora. Relax."

"Adora," Glimmer began, "Adam is probably talking to his parents right now. Then they'll probably take some time to set up a formal dinner to welcome us as ambassadors from another planet."

"In other words," Catra grinned, "just chill out for like an hour and you'll get to eat at the end of it."

Adora couldn't help but laugh at that. The buzzing knot in her chest loosened just a bit.

"After the initial pleasantries and small-talk, my first priority is to ask the king and queen about your kidnapping," Glimmer continued. "If they don't know anything about it personally, they'll almost certainly be able to help us get in touch with someone who can help us. Okay?"

"Okay," Adora said. She took deep breaths, and made herself lean back into Catra's protective embrace.

"Whatever happens, whatever we find out, we're with you, Adora," said Bow.

=======

About an hour later, Duncan arrived to escort the Etherians to a small dining hall. There to meet them were Adam and two people who must have been his parents. Adam's father was tall and powerfully built with reddish-brown hair streaked with gray. His mother was only slightly shorter, with blonde hair and blue-gray eyes like her son.

Glimmer stepped to the front of the group and offered a polite bow.

"I am Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon from the planet Etheria," she said. "Thank you for inviting us into your home."

"I am King Randor of Eternia," Adam's father said, stepping forward to meet Glimmer and clasping hands. "This is my wife, Queen Marleena."

Marleena also clasped hands with Glimmer.

The king and queen gestured toward the table, and everyone sat down. Servants quickly brought out a fine meal (Entrapta asked if there were smaller portions), and after a few minutes, the conversation continued.

"I must admit I was sceptical of my son's claim," Randor began. "Visitors from another world? But our Man-at-Arms confirmed what Adam told us. *And* he said that He-Man vouches for you all."

And so the conversation continued for a while, Glimmer doing most of the talking, explaining in brief the events that had led them here. She told them about Etheria, the First Ones, about the war with the Galactic Horde, and about the Heart of Etheria. Randor, Marleena, and Adam were enrapt with the tale.

"That Heart of Etheria thing sounds terrifying," Adam said.

"Good that you were able to permanently disable it," added Marleena. "To think such a horrible force of destruction existed for so long."

"That sort of brings me to the main reason we've come here," Glimmer continued. "See, we're pretty sure Eternia was originally a First Ones' colony, and that your people are their descendants. Horde Prime wiped out the rest of their empire centuries ago, but it seems he didn't know about this planet."

"It's what Teela and I have been thinking about for a long time, dad," Adam said. "We've seen writings and murals that suggest our ancient ancestors travelled among the stars. I mean, I've seen carvings that look *just* like the ship they came in!"

"This is a lot to take in," Randor said, "but fascinating. Please, your highness, continue."

"Right," said Glimmer. "So Etheria has a champion a lot like He-Man," she gestured to Adora. "Ours is called She-Ra. The First Ones needed her power to channel the magic for their weapon, so

they used their tech to force She-Ra to manifest in one of their own. But when that She-Ra found out what her people were up to and tried to stop it, she sent Etheria into an empty dimension so the Heart couldn't be used to hurt anyone."

"And a thousand years later," joined in Bow, "the computer in control of the Heart hijacked a portal that Hordak created to bring another First One to Etheria to eventually become She-Ra and complete the weapon."

"And that was me," said Adora. "Light Hope kidnapped me. Pulled me through the portal from somewhere else, possibly here, when I was just a baby."

At that, Marleena looked at Randor, her eyes widening. He looked back at her.

"It…" he began, "no, it couldn't be."

"Couldn't be what?" Adora asked.

"Dad?" said Adam. "Mom?"

"Adam," Marleena said. "There's something your father and I never told you." Tears began welling in her eyes.

"Marleena, you don't have to-" Randor began, but Marleena waved him off.

"When you were born," she continued, "you had a twin. A twin sister. You were only a few weeks old…"

=======

Randor and Marleena had just gotten the babies to sleep and were just on the verge of drifting off themselves, when a terrible

roar echoed through the castle halls. It was like a continuous roll of thunder *inside* the castle. The new parents sprang out of bed and tore open the door to the hall. The nursery door lay on the floor, blown off its hinges. Fierce wind whipped through the corridor, and a flickering purple light shone out from the destroyed doorway.

Marleena was sprinting down the hall without a thought, Randor barely half a step behind. Though the nursery was only twenty feet away, it felt like it took horrible hours to cross the distance, the only sound cutting through the cacophony to Marleena's ears were the screaming cries of her babies.

Just as she reached the threshold of the door, the purple light winked out with another bang of displaced air. Clothes, blankets, and diapers were scattered everywhere. Furniture, including the bassinets, were shattered and strewn about. Marleena could still hear a baby crying. She threw aside a pile of blankets and found little Adam, tiny, defenseless, and terrified, and dropped to her knees to scoop him up into her arms.

Randor frantically dug through the debris, the royal guards who arrived moments later lending a hand. But she was nowhere to be found. There was no trace. She'd simply vanished.

=======

Adora was shaking, a knot in her throat, tears welling in her eyes, as Marleena and Randor told their story. She glanced around the table, seeing tears in Bow and Glimmer's eyes too. Adora realized she was squeezing Catra's hand very tightly, and tried to make herself loosen her grip.

"All these years," Randor continued. "We'd made peace with it as best we could. And we hoped that, whatever happened, our daughter was somehow safe."

Adora couldn't speak. Could it really be that simple? It just seemed like too much of a coincidence. But the light they'd described… it reminded Adora of the visions she'd had of the portal that brought her to Etheria.

"Why…" Adam said, his voice cracking slightly, "why didn't you ever tell me?" His cheeks were wet with tears.

"We thought it better you didn't know," Marleena said. "We thought we could spare you the grief we've had to carry all this time."

"I don't know what to say, Adora," King Randor said, looking her in the eye. "What you say happened to you sounds so much like what happened to our daughter, but… it's just too much a coincidence, isn't it?"

Adora looked at Catra, but her face was unreadable, which meant she was upset. These days, Catra only hid behind her mask of indifference when her emotions were running particularly high.

Suddenly, a loud buzzing beep cut through the heavy silence at the table. Everyone looked at Entrapta, who had her facemask down and was engrossed in her tracker pad.

"Sorry," Entrapta said, lifting up her mask. "Everyone was getting very emotional and I was getting uncomfortable, so I… Anyway, Adora, I just had a *fascinating* result come back from that hair sample I took from Adam earlier."

Entrapta's hair carried the tracker pad across the table to hold it in front of Adora's face. Adora, for her part, didn't understand anything she was looking at.

"Uhhhh," Adora started.

"Oh right," Entrapta said. "If my analysis is correct - which it is - you and Adam share a fifty-percent genetic match."

"Wait, what did you match Adam's hair sample to?" asked Bow.

"Oh I have genetic sample from all of you," said Entrapta.

"Wait, when did you collect genetic sample from us?" Glimmer demanded.

"Uhhh…"

"Entrapta," Adora said, standing up from her seat, "what does that mean."

"Well," Entrapta explained, "either it's a complete coincidence - the odds of that are incredibly astronomical - or you and Adam are siblings."

Marleena suddenly stood up as well, knocking over her drinking glass and chair in the process. She made her way, almost staggering around the table. Adora stepped away from her chair to step toward her, meeting in between.

"Mx… Entrapta," Marleena said, voice quivering. "You're certain?"

"Data. Never. Lies."

Marleena looked back at Adora, into her eyes. Adora's mouth was dry. Her shaking hands felt cold. The knot in her throat felt like it might suffocate her. Finally, she managed to choke out a single, whispered word:

"Mom?"

Marleena's expression cracked. She flung her arms around Adora, both of them sinking to the floor. They were both crying, Adora silently in shock, Marleena with ragged, body-shaking sobs. After a moment, two more sets of arms and weeping eyes joined the embrace.

Glimmer had a hand to her mouth and both she and Bow were weeping as well. Entrapta, had quietly put her mask back down, not knowing how to respond to the obvious extreme emotion.

Catra stared at Adora, the woman she loved, on the floor enveloped in the arms of her mother, father, and brother. Catra's heart was bursting for Adora. But at the back of her mind, a familiar spiteful voice whispered to her in the secret language of all her old fears and anxieties.

So in this moment, with all eyes transfixed by this family's long overdue reunion, Catra quietly stood up from her seat at the table

and walked out of the room.

Chapter End Notes

This one was a lot of fun and a bit emotional to write. I'm a parent, so trying to get into the headspace of characters who'd lost a child was... a lot.

Anyway, thanks for reading! I hope you're still enjoying it. I may come back to edit this chapter later, because I feel like I might have rushed a few parts trying to get to the dinner scene.

Thanks again, and stay tuned for the next chapter.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Wrong Hordak leaned over the wash basin in Darla's restroom. He stared intently at his face, curious if the intended modification would work. He closed his currently blue eyes and focused. When he opened them again, the left eye was purple.

"Hoohoo!" he cried with a wide grin.

Then the ship's communication console began to chime. Wrong Hordak made his way to the bridge to answer the incoming call. When the screen came to life, Wrong Hordak saw the familiar sight of a face nearly identical to his own, albeit with dark blue hair and red eyes rimmed with black makeup.

"Brother!" Wrong Hordak greeted his fellow clone. "Look! I have made my eyes two *different* colors."

"Um…" said Hordak, "excellent?"

"Thank you!"

"I… must speak to Entrapta," Hordak continued. "Where is she?"

"Entrapta is not currently on board," Wrong Hordak replied. "She and the others are exploring this planet and befriending its inhabitants. Melog and I are watching the ship."

"Hmm. Well, when she returns, tell her that her plans for repairing the Sea Gate were a complete success. The energy field is almost fully restored."

"I will, brother."

"Also… tell her I… Just ask her to contact me when she returns."

"Of course, brother. Is there anything else I can-" Wrong Hordak stopped short.

Melog had uncurled from its nap and had its front paws up on the control panel, looking out the ship's canopy. Wrong Hordak followed its gaze and saw Entrapta walking toward the ship waving.

"Why, here she comes now!" he told Hordak. "Just wait a moment and you can speak to her directly."

"Thank you, brother," said Hordak.

Wrong Hordak started toward the landing ramp, Melog at his heel.

Something was off, Melog thought. Why was Entrapta back alone?

The landing ramp lowered, and Wrong Hordak enthusiastically beckoned to Entrapta… who did not react or change pace. Something wasn't right. Entrapta would be more excited about a message from Hordak. And there was something else… Melog sensed magic… but not Adora's or Glimmer's.

Melog leaped in front of Wrong Hordak, flashing it's mane red and baring its teeth at the not-Entrapta.

"Melog!" Wrong Hordak said in confusion. "What are you-" Then the illusion of Entrapta vanished. In its place was a green-skinned woman in black, armored robes and a metallic blue headdress.

Wrong Hordak gasped and started backing up the ramp. Melog moved to follow… but couldn't move! While it'd been focused on the illusion and the sorceress that cast it, something had seized around its mind like a net. This was a different kind of magic, something Melog hadn't encountered before.

Then two other figures emerged from the treeline.

One had a metallic ring around his head like a blindfold. The ring was adorned with multiple mechanical lenses and irises which

shifted and focused as the ring rotated.

The other was hulking and hunched, covered in red-orange fur. Drool trickled from its fang-filled mouth as it knuckle-walked toward the ship, the pupils of its eyes shining yellow.

Melog felt it: the red-furred one was the source of the power ensnaring its mind.

"Take them," the green-skinned woman said. And the other two broke into a sprint.

Wrong Hordak turned and scrambled into the ship, rushing to the controls.

"What is it?" Hordak called from the still active screen. "Where is she?"

"Not Entrapta," Wrong Hordak stammered, trying to remember what buttons to press. "Imposters! Intrud-"

Hordak saw a red-orange blur flash across the screen and heard a thud that cut off the other clone's words.

"What's happening?" Hordak demanded. "Wrong Hordak! Brother!"

"Shut that off," said a woman's cold voice. A figure appeared on the screen for a moment, pressed some controls, and the signal cut off.

=======

Catra sat on the parapet of one of the castle's towers, looking out over the city. The sun was just past the horizon, and the sky was slowly shifting from blazing red into deep purple, the stars

beginning to appear in the gathering dark. She watched as lanterns began to flicker on in the city below.

"Catra?" Adora called out from behind her.

As always, Adora's voice calling her name spread a warm feeling in Catra's chest, but it was also tinged with embarrassment at the situation. And a touch of shame from running away. Again. Ugh, why was she like this? Catra drew both knees up to her chest and wrapped both arms and her tail around them.

"I figured I'd find you in the highest spot it was possible to get to," Adora continued, stepping up to the parapet beside her. "Catra, what are you doing up here?"

A long silence passed between them, Adora waiting - not pushing - for Catra to come to her. At last, Catra looked up at the sky, closed her eyes, and let out a heavy sigh.

"I'm being stupid," she said.

"Catra…"

"Adora, I am *so* happy for you," Catra said. "Like, I don't even have words. It's just… incredible and wonderful that we found them, that you can have these answers you wanted."

She slid back off the ledge onto the roof beside Adora and hugged herself.

"But when I saw you all together like that…" she trailed off. "All those old fears just rushed up on me again. And that… *mean* voice in the back of my head said, 'How dare you think you get what you want. How dare you think you get to be happy.' And it's always… *her* voice…"

Catra turned and took Adora's hands in hers. She looked into her blue-gray eyes that shone in the twilight.

"I love you," Catra said, "and I trust you, and I *know* you're not going to leave me. *I know that* ." She looked down. "But I couldn't help it. The thought was just *there.* 'She's found her *real* family now. She's found her *real* home. There's no reason for her to go back with *you.* '"

"Catra," Adora breathed. "I'm… *so* excited that I found my parents. And finding out that I have a brother? It's just...wow. But most of all, I'm *so* happy that you were here with me when I did."

She reached up and cupped Catra's cheek with one hand. Catra nuzzled into it, tears in her eyes as they met Adora's.

"But listen to me, ok?" Adora continued. "My *family* is on Etheria. And my *home* is with *you.* "

Catra smiled. "Promise?" she said.

"I promise," Adora replied, pulling Catra into a tight hug.

They held each other for a long time, the itchy panic at the base of Catra's spine gradually fading away. Finally, she let out another sigh.

"I'm sorry," said Catra.

"Don't be," Adora said. "I understand. I… Sometimes I still hear her in my head too."

Catra pulled back to look at Adora's face.

"You do?" she said.

Adora looked away.

"Not as much as I used to, but… usually when I'm having a lot of fun, or feeling really happy, or feeling relaxed… Then suddenly she's there, 'Surely there's something more important you could be doing right now.' Some goal I should be working on or some

mission I should be focusing on. But do you want to know what I do when it does?"

Catra nodded.

"I remind myself that she can't hurt me anymore," Adora looked back up to meet Catra's eyes again. "That she can't hurt *you* anymore. That this is *my* life, and I can live it how I want."

"Adora…"

Adora leaned in to kiss Catra.

"I love you," she said.

"I love you, too," replied Catra.

Adora looked out over the city as full dark neared.

"Wow," she said, "the city is really beautiful at night."

Catra wasn't looking at the city.

"Yeah it is," she said.

"C'mon," Adora cried, taking Catra by the hand and grinning widely, "let's go check it out!"

Catra smiled too, and together, they raced down from the tower and out into the city night.

Chapter End Notes

As always, thanks for reading!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was very late by the time Adora and Catra returned to the castle, sneaking over one of the walls, tired and giggling.

"Where are we even going to sleep?" Adora asked.

"I don't even care," Catra replied. "I'm *so* beat. I could sleep just about anywhere right now."

"Like that time when we were six, and you took a nap on that cooling tower and couldn't get down?"

"Oh, you would bring that up," Catra said, her tail bristling slightly.

"And I had to stand on Rogelio's shoulers, and Lonnie on mine, and Kyle on hers, to try and get you down?" Adora was laughing harder now.

"Shut up!" Catra laughed, giving Adora a playful shove.

Someone nearby cleared thier throat. Adora and Catra froze and turned to look at the figure that had approached them. It was one of the castle guards.

"You're back," the guard said, clearly irritated. "Sleeping quarters have been arranged for the event of your return. Follow me."

Catra and Adora followed the guard, trying unsuccessfully to suppress their giggling. At last they were left at a door, and Adora tried to hold a straight face long enough to thank the guard. Eventually, Adora and Catra fell into bed, gradually stopped laughing and giggling, and fell asleep in each other's arms.

=======

It was still dark out when Adora was awoken by a whispered voice and a gentle nudge on her shoulder. She couldn't have been asleep for more than a few hours. Adora opened her eyes slowly to see Adam's face looking down at her. She started and let out a short surprised cry.

"Sorry!" Adam said, quietly.

"Whoozat?" Catra mumbled, her ear twitching.

"Adam," Adora said, rubbing her eyes, "what are you doing here? What time is it?"

"Sorry," Adam said again. "It's early. Like, super-before-dawn-early. I just think it's really important you come see Castle Grayskull, and that'll be easier before my p-... our... before everyone else wakes up."

"No," Catra said, swatting her arm in Adam's general direction. "No castles. Only sleeping."

"Catra," Adora began, "I think he's right. I should definitely check out this Grayskull place." She remembered Catra's episode from the night before. "But I won't go right now if you want me to stay."

Catra sighed. "No, it's ok," she said. "He's right. Probably good to go while everyone else is still asleep. Plus, I can cover for you if you're not back before breakfast; I'll just hiss at anyone who tries to come in."

Adora chuckled. "Thanks. I'll be back soon." She kissed Catra on the forehead and slid out of bed.

A few minutes later, Adora and Adam had boarded a Royal Guard skiff and were soaring past the outer wall of the city.

“How far is the castle?” Adora asked over the wind.

“Not too far on this skiff,” Adam called back. “On foot it would take half the day, but with this, we’ll be there before dawn.”

A few silent minutes passed. Adora recalling the last time she rode a skiff before sunrise en route to see First Ones artifacts… Finally, Adam broke the silence.

“Is it weird that it feels more awkward talking to you now that I know you’re my sister?” he said.

“What do you mean?” Adora replied.

“I…” he shook his head. “I don’t really know what I mean. It’s like, I don’t really know you; I barely know anything about you, and yet this connection just exists between us. I don’t know, like, it just feels weird.”

Adora considered this for a moment.

“I guess it makes sense,” Adora said at last. “For a long time, I honestly didn’t feel like where I came from was relevant to my life. Then wanting to find out just kind of stuck in my head and wouldn’t leave me alone. Now I’ve found you all, and… I guess I don’t really know what to do with it. I want to get to know you and… and our parents, but it just feels weird. Like, ‘Hi, I’m your long-lost daughter/sister! Let’s share a lot of personal information then, bye! I’m going home to my other planet now!’ That just feels weird.”

“So… you are planning to leave then?” Adam asked.

“I have to,” Adora responded. “I’m thrilled that I found you guys, but Etheria is my home.”

“For having just met you, I’m… kind of surprised how sad that makes me feel right now…”

“Yeah…” Adora agreed. “But! We’ve got some tech in our ship that we can leave here that’ll let us stay in touch and open a portal between Eternia and Etheria any time we want.”

Adam smiled at that. “Well that’s good then. We’re here.”

Adora looked ahead of the skiff. It was an impressive sight. Ahead of them was a rocky gorge, in the middle of which stood a singular, narrow plateau. On the plateau stood an imposing stone edifice: a four-towered fortress of greenish stone that wrapped around a craggy central peak that looked somehow familiar. But the most striking feature of the citadel was the front wall: carved in the shape of a sinister-looking fanged skull.

Adam landed the skiff, and he and Adora walked to the cliff edge across from the skull-faced wall. Adora peeked cautiously over the edge, seeing that the chasm stretched deep into the ground. Too deep to see any sign of the bottom.

“How do we?” Adora asked, gesturing at the castle.

Adam grinned, and drew the sword off his back. He held it up, and the disant eyes of the castle flashed briefly with light. The door within the mouth slid open as a crystalline bridge extended itself across the gap to meet them. Adam strode confidently across, but Adora couldn’t help but feel anxious about the drop below them. She let out a breath she hadn’t realized she was holding once they reached the other side.

“So,” Adam said, “the outside of this place is designed to look pretty spooky, but wait til you see the inside!”

As they crossed the threshold, the bridge retracted, and the door slid back up to shut them in. After a moment in darkness, an ambient glow gradually illuminated the interior. The sight drew a gasp from Adora’s mouth.

“Pretty wild, right?” Adam said.

“It… it looks just like the Crystal Castle on Etheria,” said Adora.

Indeed it did. The walls, floor, ceiling, and columns all bore the unmistakable crystal-like structure of the First Ones ruins on Etheria, including the blue-pink-and-purple sheen to the environment.

“Crystal Castle, huh?” Adam said. “Add another mystery to the pile.”

They walked further into the main chamber. The building wasn’t laid out exactly like the Crystal Castle, but it was very similar.

“You said a sorceress lives here?” Adora inquired.

“Yeah,” said Adam. “Guess you should meet her. Sorceress!”

Adam’s voice echoed through the crystalline chamber. For a moment, there was only silence, but then an eerily familiar electronic buzzing sound filled the room. A moment later, a shimmering, translucent figure faded into view in front of them. A figure Adora recognized at once.

“Light Hope?” she said, taking a step back from the blue holographic woman who had appeared before them.

“Light… no, Adora, this is the Sorceress,” Adam said, confused.

“I am indeed an iteration of the Light Hope facilitator program,” the hologram said. “Designation: Sorceress.”

“Wait, you are?” Adam said. “You never told me that.”

“It was not relevant information for your role as He-Man, Adam,” she said. The Sorceress looked at Adora. “Who is this?”

“Oh!” he said, stepping over to Adora. “You’re never gonna believe this, but this is Adora. My sister.”

“Greetings, Adora,” the Sorceress said.

“Hi…” Adora said. She was wary of this program after what Light Hope had done, and it was unsettling to see the same face again. But, she supposed, this *was* a different version of her.

“So…” Adam began, sensing the awkward tension in the air, “Sorceress, why don’t you tell Adora what we do here?”

“I am the facilitator of the Grayskull facility,” the Sorceress said. “My function is to ensure the preservation of Grayskull and to select and train individuals to be He-Man.”

“And what’s so important about Castle Grayskull?” Adam probed.

“That information is classified,” the Sorceress responded.

“See,” Adam said to Adora. “She never tells me anything. So… I protect the castle’s secrets.” He looked back at the hologram. “Ok, that’s all for now, I guess. Not really getting any training in today, just wanted to show Adora around.”
The Sorceress nodded and flickered away.

“C’mon,” Adam said. “I want to show you the murals Teela and I were talking about before.”

For a while, Adam led Adora around the parts of the castle he had access to. There were definitely more images and depictions of the First Ones here than in the castle on Etheria. Adora felt her unease gradually fade.

“This is pretty neat, I guess” she said at last. “And obviously, Mara was here once, so there’s that.” She ran her fingers along one of the carvings.
“Mara?” Adam asked.

“Oh,” Adora said. “She was the She-Ra before me. The one who led a rebellion against our ancestors and tried to stop the Heart of Etheria.”

“No,” Adam said, “it’s not that… that name… follow me.”

Adam took off down another set of corridors, eventually leading them to a hallway lined with many doors. Each door had a plaque on the wall next to it with writing on it. As they walked past several doors, Adora realized they were name plates.

“Here,” Adam said, stopping by one of the doors and pointing.

Adora looked, and the nameplate by the door said…

“Mara?” Adora breathed. “What is this? Where are we?”

“These rooms look like they were residential suites for people who lived here a long time ago,” Adam explained. “Not really much left of anything though.” He tapped on the nameplate, and the door slid open.

Inside, the room was small. Maybe a little bigger the room Adora shared with Catra on board Darla. There was an elevated platform that was clearly meant for a bed, though any mattress was long gone. There were some shelves and appliances that resembled the kitchen on the ship as well. Also, there was another door to the side that Adora presumed led to a bathroom. Lastly, on the same wall as the entry door, there was a small desk and chair. Adora stepped into the small room.

“Did- did she really live here once?” Adora wondered aloud.

“This Mara really means a lot to you, doesn’t she?” Adam asked.

“Don’t you feel that way about the others who came before you as He-Man?”

“I mean, I do, but I don’t know who any of them were by name.” He shrugged. “Classified.”

Adora frowned slightly, but still explored the room. She tried to picture Mara living here. Resting on the bed, preparing meals in the tiny kitchen. Working at the desk… As Adora looked closer at the desk, she noticed buttons similar to those on Darla’s comms console. She tried pressing one.

“That’s no use,” Adam said. “Teela and I have been through every one of these rooms, and none of the buttons on the desks do anything.”

Adora had an idea. She closed her eyes and tried to call up just a little of She-Ra’s magic. When she opened her eyes, they glowed bright blue, and she touched the controls on the desk again. This time, the panel lit up.

“Woah!” Adam cried. “How did you do that?”

“You have no new messages,” a tinny voice from the desk said.

“Is there… anything to play back at all?” Adora inquired.

“Draft of last sent message is available,” the desk replied. “Would you like me to play it?”

“Yes.”

There was a buzzing sound not unlike the one when the Sorceress appeared, and a hologram flickered to life just behind Adora. She gasped as the figure of Mara appeared in the chair. Mara looked… cheerful. None of the weight or regret Adora had seen her carrying in previous recordings of her.

“Is that?” Adam began, but he stopped because the hologram had begun to speak.

“Hey, Mom!” Mara began. “Just wanted to make sure to send one last message before the big day! I can’t believe we’re *finally* leaving for Etheria tomorrow. Or that *I* was chosen to be She-Ra, for that matter. Oh, but that’s supposed to be all hush-hush.” She laughed. “Everyone’s so excited to get to study Etheria’s inhabitants, wildlife, culture, magic. Just, such a big adventure for the ol’ Grayskull Squad. Anyway, I know it’s late there, so you probably won’t get this until we’re already on our way, so make sure to send your reply to the station on Etheria. Love you, Mom. Bye!”

The image flickered away. Tears welled in Adora's eyes. Seeing Mara so… normal, so *happy* . It was bittersweet. At once, it was wonderful to see her so carefree, unburdened by the horrors that waited for her on Etheria. But on the other hand, Adora knew the nightmare that this Mara would soon have to face, and knowing what that kind, innocent young woman was going to have to go through… it kind of broke her heart.

"Something's wrong here, isn't it?" Adam said after a long moment. "You've been on edge ever since I showed you the Sorceress."

"There's some connection between this place and what happened on Etheria," Adora said. "And... after what our ancestors did, I can't help but worry about what the Sorceress won't tell you." Her eyes narrowed. "But maybe there's someone she *will* give answers to."

Chapter End Notes

As always, thanks for reading!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Sorceress,” Adam called, back in the main chamber.

The hologram resolved into view once more, and Adam looked to Adora.

“Tell us about the Heart of Etheria,” Adora said.

“That information is classified,” the Sorceress said.

“Yeah, we’ll see about that.” Adora held out her hand and summoned her sword. “For the honor of Grayskull!”

Adora transformed in a flash of light. Now She-Ra stood in the chamber, the light of her aura reflecting off the polished walls and floor. The Sorceress’s image stutterd for a moment.

“Administrator detected,” she said. “Welcome, She-Ra.”

“You were right…” said Adam.

Part of Adora wished she hadn’t been.

“Now,” Adora said to the Sorceress, “tell us about this place. What is Grayskull? What is He-Man?”

"The Grayskull facility's primary objective was the creation of the Sword of Protection as part of the Heart of Etheria project," the Sorceress explained. "This was necessary to control She-Ra's power for use with the Heart. However, contact was lost with the outposts on Etheria, so a new course of action was required.

"Since few planets produce as much magic as Etheria, construction began of an array of Hearts on various worlds. Grayskull was repurposed as a nexus for that network, the Eye of

the Galaxy. In addition, with She-Ra lost with Etheria, a replacement component was required. Thus, He-Man and the Sword of Power were created."

"What does that mean?" Adam asked.

The Sorceress looked at him. "That information is classified."

Adora groaned. "Can I just make He-Man an administrator, too?"

"Acknowledged."

"Answer him then."

"He-Man is an artificial facsimile of She-Ra," the Sorceress said. "Designed to act as the critical firing mechanism of the Eye in her place."

Adam, staggered back a step, his head swimming. He turned abruptly and ran for the door. Adora transformed back and followed after him.

"Adam!" Adora called, trying to catch up with him as he crossed the bridge toward the skiff. "Adam, wait!"

The sun was just up. The sky was still dark blue in the west, but it bled to pink and orange as it arched across to the other horizon.

Adam stopped beside the skiff, leaning against it and hanging his head. Adora finally caught up with him and stopped to catch her breath. Behind them, the bridge began to retract.

“Adam…” Adora started.

Suddenly, Adam took the sword off his back and threw it as hard as he could. It clattered to the rocky ground a few yards from him. He slumped to his knees and put his face in his hands.

“Adam,” Adora said, “I’m sorry...”

"I grew up on stories of He-Man, y'know," Adam said. He looked up at his sister, tears in his eyes. "The legendary hero of Eternia. So when I got to *become* him… It meant everything to me. I'm going to be king someday, and what my parents do to lead Eternia is important. But as He-Man? I thought I could make a *real* difference."

Adora said nothing.

"But it's all a lie," Adam continued, looking over at the sword on the ground. "He-Man's not a hero. He's a weapon of mass destruction. A twisted experiment by our ancestors to murder billions of people."

"But that's not going to happen now," Adora said. "The Sorceress is waiting on orders that aren't coming. The First Ones never finished the Eye." Adora walked over to pick up Adam's sword and stepped in front of him. "Our ancestors may have made He-Man as a weapon, but *you* make him a hero, just like the others that had his power before you did." Adora held the sword out to her brother, offering him the hilt. " *You* have the power. It's up to you how you use it."

Adam looked up at Adora, then at the sword. He thought of the adventures he'd had as He-Man. The dangers he'd thwarted, the lives he'd saved. He thought of how he was the only thing standing between Skeletor and Grayskull-

"I can't let Skeletor get his hands on the castle," he said. "All the information in there… about the sword, the Heart, the Eye. If that knowledge ever fell into his hands…"

"So He-Man still has to protect the secrets of Grayskull," Adora said. "But now you and every He-Man to follow after you will know what those secrets are."

Adam reached up and took hold of the sword. He stood up and returned the sword to the scabbard on his back. He wiped the tears from his eyes.

“Thanks, Adora,” he said.

“I’ve been where you are,” Adora said. “When I found out about the Heart of Etheria and the part I was intended to play in it, it was overwhelming and terrifying. I was looking for a destiny too. But I can tell you what it took me a long time to figure out.” She put a hand on Adam’s shoulder. “You get to make *your own* destiny.”

Adam pulled Adora into a hug, which she gladly returned.

“Look at me,” Adam said. “I’ve had a big sister for a whole day and a half, and she’s already taking care of me. What would I ever do without you?”

They both laughed.

“Well from now on,” Adora said, “neither of us have to find out.”

“Right,” Adam smiled. “C’mon, we should get back.”

Adam and Adora climbed back into the skiff and soared off back toward the city as the sun rose over Eternia.

=======

Catra paced on the landing platform, her tail lashing anxiously.

“Where are they?” Glimmer asked again.

“I told you I don’t know,” Catra spat back. She stopped and took a breath. “Adam was taking her to see that Grayskull place. They wanted to go early before everyone woke up. The plan was for them to be back before breakfast.”

“Ok, so they’re not overdue back yet,” Bow said, rubbing his eyes. “Nobody but the four of us are up yet.”

Entrapta was also with them. She sat on a crate next to one of the skiffs fiddling with her trackerpad. She hummed nervously as the pad kept giving her a buzz in response to her prodding.

Suddenly, Catra's ear twitched as she picked up a faint sound in the distance. It was different than the ones in the Horde, but it was definitely the sound of a skiff engine.

"I think they're coming," she said. She stepped to the edge of the platform and sheilded her eyes from the rising sun.

"I don't hear anything," Glimmer said.

"It's probably too far off still to pick up with your tiny ears," Catra said with a smirk.

"Ooh, watch it, Horde scum," Glimmer jabbed back with a grin.

"Wait," said Bow, who was looking through his binoculars, "I think I see them!"

A few moments later, the skiff came in for a landing, and Adora and Adam jumped off.

"What happened to coving for us until breakfast?" Adora chuckled.

"Adora, listen," said Bow. "Something's wrong."

"What?" Adora said. "What's wrong?"

"Entrapta woke us all up because she can't get ahold of Wrong Hordak on the ship," Catra said.

"Hordak was supposed to get in touch about the Sea Gate in Salenias," Entrapta said, looking up from the trackerpad. "So I tried to call Darla to see if he had, but there's been no response."

"Could he just be asleep?" Adora asked.

"Even if he was," Entrapta explained, one again poking at the pad, "Darla would have acknowledged the incoming call. Someone's

turned off the communications system entirely!”

“We can take the skiffs,” Adam chimed in. “I’ll get Teela and Duncan. We’ll head back to the forest right away.” He raced off down the hall.

“Entrapta,” said Bow, “is there any chance that something just broke? Maybe the comms just shorted out?”

“I suppose it’s possible,” Entrapta replied. “But regardless, I want to get back to Darla as quickly as possible.”

A few minutes later, Adam returned with Teela and Duncan. They divided up between the two skiffs - Adam, Adora, Teela, and Catra on one, Duncan, Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta on the other - and sailed off into the early morning air. Within minutes they were passing over the outer edge of the forest where they’d left the ship.

“How come you guys go on patrol on foot?” Bow asked Duncan. “These skiffs are way faster.”

“And louder,” Duncan replied. “Much easier for Skeletor’s scouts and spies to see and hear coming and avoid us.”

Moments later, the skiffs soared over the clearing where they’d left the ship. It was nowhere in sight.

“Entrapta, anything?” asked Glimmer.

“No,” Entrapta replied. “But if Melog is cloaking her, I wouldn’t be able to pick up a reading. We need to land.”

Adam and Duncan landed the skiffs on the edge of the clearing, and everyone piled out. They fanned out, feeling around for the ship while Entrapta called out for it.

“There’s nothing,” Teela said. “It’s not here.”

“Wait, look at this,” Adora said. She’d spotted some prints in the dirt between the treeline and where Darla had been. “It looks like footprints and… fist-prints?”

“Beastman,” Adam said. “One of Skeletor’s lieutenants. If they took your ship.”

“Would they have...hurt our friends,” Catra asked. Her hands were clenched in fists. Adora put a reassuring hand on her shoulder.

“Not likely,” Duncan replied. “At least not yet. Skeletor tends to try and bend prisoners to his use or use them as leverage before harming them.”

“If Skeletor has taken their ship,” Adam said, “he’ll have had it brought to Snake Mountain.”

“Snake Mountain?” said Glimmer.

“A mountaintop fortress on the other side of a desert,” Teela explained. “Adam, we can’t just go charging in there.”

“Why not,” Adam said with a smirk. “We’ve done it before.”
“And you barely made it out alive,” Duncan scolded.

“We have to do something,” Bow said. “There’s all kinds of tech in that ship that we can’t let Skeletor figure out how to use.”

“We go charging into places without a plan all the time,” Adora said.

“Plus, this Skeletor creep has never had to deal with the five of us,” Catra added.

“Alright,” Duncan said with a scowl. “I can see I’m outvoted by you kids. At least I can come along and try to keep you from getting yourselves killed.”

=======

The hangar doors slid open with a squeal of metal. Skeletor strode through at a brisk pace, punctuating every few steps with a strike of his staff on the floor. Armored guards knelt at his passage. To one side, the Beastman crouched low to the ground in deference to the superior predator. Evil-lyn stood between Skeletor and the object of his interest. She knelt as he approached.

“My lord,” she began, “Tri-klops is within attempting to decipher the technol-”

She stopped as Skeletor walked past her without a word. He ascended the entry ramp of the crystalline vessel and entered the ship. Tri-klops was at the control panel of the bridge, looking over the buttons and scratching his head. He paused at the sound of the approaching footsteps.

“Is he coming?” Tri-klops said. “I still haven’t figured out-” His cybernetic eyepiece swivelled and one of the lenses focused on Skeletor. He let out a surprised yelp and dropped to one knee. “Master!”

“Leave,” Skeletor demanded.

Tri-klops sprang to his feet and ran out of the ship.

Skeletor ran a hand along the lines and edges of the control console. It had been so long since he’d seen such a vessel, perhaps as ancient as Grayskull itself. He strode quickly to the command throne at the center of the bridge and sat down. He shifted his staff to his left hand and pressed a panel on the arm of the seat.

There was a tone. A pause.

“Administrator detected.”

=======

Some time later, Seketor emerged from the ship.

“Bring the prisoners to my throne room,” he barked at Evil-lyn. “And prepare the fortress for an incursion.”

Evil-lyn nodded, then gestured to the soldiers. One took hold of the chains binding the pointy-eared prisoner with the mismatched eyes while two others lifted the cage holding the feline creature. The latter flashed its ephemeral red mane and snarled at its captors. The former merely wimpered in fear. The soldiers marched the prisoners out of the hangar.

“I will wait with our guests for our new arrivals,” Skeletor said. “Leave the defenses to Tri-klops. I have another task for you, Evil-lyn.”

=======

The skiffs soared over the cracked and rocky ground. The land was completely barren, unsettlingly so. Even the Crimson Wastes on Etheria had all manner of strange flora and fauna (not to mention things that seemed to be a little of both), but this place was completely devoid of any signs of life.

Glimmer shivered despite the heat. There was something very wrong here.

“What happened to this place?” Bow asked.

“No one is really sure,” Duncan said, “but it certainly seems to be Skeletor’s doing. No one knows how long his fortress at Snake Mountain has been here - his all-out war against the kingdom only really started about ten years ago - but this desert has been expanding for as long as anyone alive can remember.”

“It’s awful,” Glimmer said, hugging herself. “This place feels...dead.”

Ahead of them, a line of mountains like broken fangs rose out of the hard landscape. Above their peaks hung thick black clouds that occasionally flashed with unnaturally colored lightning deep within, faint thunder rolling out across the hardpan.

“They’re definitely going to see us coming!” Duncan called out to the other skiff.

"So what's plan?" Teela said.

"Uhhh..." Adam and Adora said in unison, looking at each other.

"Oh no," Catra said, rubbing her temple. "Now there's two of them."

"Oh," Teela said with narrowed, knowing eyes, "so she's like that too."

Catra sighed, then called over to the other skiff. “We just need to get our friends and the ship back. In and out, quick. Adam and Adora can transform and keep them distracted. Arrow Boy and the old man, you stay with the skiffs so we can get out. Entrapta and Teela find the ship. Me and Sparkles will find Wrong Hordak and Melog. This Skeletor creep hasn't encounterd most of us before, so that's our advantage. We make it fast so they don't get time to learn."

Everyone acknowledged the plan. Minutes later, they were in sight of the fortress. The skiffs flew low, hugging dangerously close to the mountainside. Suddenly, bright lances of red energy began

raining down at them: artillery fire from cannons on the ridge above.

“Right on time,” Adam said. He handed the controls over to Teela, then drew his sword. “Ready, Adora?”

Adora’s sword appeared in her hand. “Let’s do this,” she said.

“By the power-”

“For the honor-”

“-OF GRAYSKULL!”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! And for all the wonderful feedback. That's part of what makes fanfic so fun: hearing from readers who enjoy the work.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The gunner fired his cannon at the approaching skiffs. As he lined up another shot, his targeting screen went blank from an overwhelming flash of light. He looked up just in time to see an eight-foot-tall woman in white, long hair streaming behind her, sailing through the air toward him.

With a shout, her shining sword cleaved down the barrel of the cannon, the red-hot edges of the metal curling away from each other, and she drove it into the power cell. The cannon exploded, and the gunner felt himself hurled over the edge of the cliff face. Suddenly, a powerful arm gripped the collar of his armor, halting his fall. He looked, stunned into the radiating blue eyes of the giant woman before she threw him to the ground safely. As she charged off toward another cannon, the gunner scrambled to his feet and fled.

Nearby, He-Man landed next to another cannon after slicing off the end of the barrel. He stuck his sword in the rocky ground and lifted the damaged cannon over his head. He then hurled it at another cannon, destroying them both. She-Ra dodged through incoming fire from handheld blasters, then swung her sword, releasing an energy wave that knocked several of Skeletor's troops off their feet. The siblings made their way across the ridge at each other's backs, demolishing artillery and neutralizing infantry as they went.

The skiffs streaked overhead, bypassing the enemy firing line, to land near the base of the soot-black tower. Some of the soldiers broke off from attacking She-Ra and He-Man to head their way.

"We're a long way from a door," Duncan said, readying his blaster.

“Doors will be guarded,” Catra said. “Plus with this wall at your back, you only have to deal with them coming from one way.”

“Besides,” said Glimmer, “we don’t need a door!”

“You read my mind, Sparkles."

“There!” Entrapta cried. “Now that we’re close enough, I’m picking up the energy signature from Darla’s engines. I don’t have an exact location, but once we’re inside I should be able to home in on her.”

“Alright, then let’s go,” said Glimmer.

“Wait,” Teela said, “how are we getting in without a door?”

Glimmer held out her hand. “Trust me.”

Teela grasped Glimmer’s hand. Catra and Entrapta each put a hand on her shoulders.

“Glimmer,” said Bow, nocking an arrow, “be careful.”

“Be right back,” she replied with a wink. And with that, Glimmer, Teela, Catra, and Entrapta vanished in a shower of sparks.

“Ok,” said Bow. “Now we just have to hold Skeletor’s forces off until they get back.” He loosed an arrow which exploded into a net, trapping an approaching trooper.

“This is a terrible plan,” Duncan grumbled. “But that’s par for the course where Adam and my daughter are involved.” He ducked into cover on the skiff, peeking out the fire periodically at the incoming soldiers.

“Same for us,” Bow laughed. “No wonder we all make a good team!”

=======

In a flash of pink light, Glimmer, Catra, Entrapta, and Teela appeared in a darkened corridor within the Snake Mountain fortress.

“Woah, that was...something,” Teela said, suppressing a wave of nausea.

“You’ll get used to it,” Catra said. She began sniffing the air. “There! I’ve got them. Alright, Entratpa, you and Teela track down the ship and get out. We’ll find Melog and Wrong Hordak and meet the others back at the skiffs.”

“Got it,” Teela said.

“And keep a close eye on Entrapta,” Glimmer added. “She...tends to get distracted by new tech.”

“It’s true,” Entrapta added. “Sometimes I need help with that.”

“Alright,” Teela said. “See you back outside.”

The two teams split off, heading down the corridor in opposite directions.

=======

“Hey,” Adam said as he blocked a swing from a trooper's spear, "which of us do you think is stronger?" He grabbed the trooper by the collar of their armor and threw them into a group of three more.

Adora caught an incoming cannon blast on her sword and hurled it back, destroying the weapon.

“Not exactly the best time to start that kind of contest,” she said.

The ground beneath them rumbled and started to shift and crack apart. Adam and Adora leaped to either side of the growing rift as a section of the mountainside hoisted itself out of the ground, assuming a roughly humanoid shape with four massive arms. A craggy mouth split open across its chest and it roared at the warriors.

"Another rock monster?" Adora said.

"Yeah," said Adam, "a *big* one."

The monster swung one massive fist at Adam in a backhand motion. He managed to turn the blow aside, but wasn't quick enough to counter the followup from another arm. The blow caught Adam in the chest and sent him tumbling across the mountaintop.

"Adam!" Adora called.

The creature raised all four fists over its head and brought them down in a blow that cracked the ground. Adora backflipped out of the way, but quickly had to dodge again. This creature was surprisingly fast for its size, and Adora was having a hard time sidestepping its blows. The monster threw a powerful punch with its upper right arm, and Adora leaped up onto it as it drove into the ground. She ran quickly up the arm, sword glowing with magic. She carved into the beast's shoulder, cleaving off the entire arm, and jumped off to land behind it. The monster roared and recoiled, the edges of severed rock glowing with heat. Adora readied herself as the monster turned to attack again, but as she moved to parry, a chunk of rock crumbled from beneath her foot, throwing her off balance!

There was a blur of movement, and suddenly Adam was in front of her, catching the creature's massive fist with both hands. The ground cracked beneath his feet, driving him almost knee-deep in the rock, but he held his ground and pushed back with a yell. He shoved so hard that he took the monster completely off balance and knocked it onto its back.

“Thanks,” Adora said.

“What are brothers for?” Adam replied with a wink.

The rock monster climbed back to its feet and roared. Adam and Adora readied their swords and leaped toward it.

=======

“This way!” Entrapta cried as she and Teela raced down the hall.

Teela was concerned. So far, they hadn’t run into any resistance. Were all of Skeletor’s forces really outside focused on He-Man and She-Ra?

They reached a massive set of metal doors. Entrapta’s hair formed into tendrils that rapidly typed at the nearby keypad. After a moment, the console buzzed and the doors started to slide open. Teela barely saw them in time. A row of troopers waiting just inside the doors, blasters raised. Teela grabbed Entrapta around that waist and pulled her into cover just as the bolts of energy streaked by them.

“A trap,” Teela said. “They knew we were coming.”

“I’ve got an idea,” Entrapta said. “But you have to *promise* not to tell my friends I brought her on the trip.”

“Uh...sure?” Teela said, uncertain.

“Great!” Entrapta cried. She put her fingers in her mouth and whistled loudly. “Emily! C’mere, girl!”

Teela chanced a peek through the door. She saw the Etherians’ ship in the center of the hangar, and something round and pale green suddenly fell out of a cranny in its hull with a loud clang.

Spider-like metal appendages extended from its shell and it scuttled toward the troopers from behind. They heard the clank of the machine’s metal feet, but too late. They were blasted off their feet by beams of purple energy emitting from what seemed to be its eye.

After barreling through the line of troopers, the robot scurried through the door and toward Entrapta. She wrapped her arms and hair around it in a hug.

"Good girl!" she cried. Lifting herself up with her hair, Entrapta sat on top of the bot. "Let's go!"

Teela nodded, and they headed toward the ship. Entrapta whistled again, and the entry ramp slid open. Suddenly, Teela caught sight of an orange blur and the pounding of feet and fists on the metal floor. The Beastman rammed his shoulder into Emily, knocking her off her legs and sending her and Entrapta spinning across the floor.

Teela quickly traced a rune in the air and threw it at the monstrous warrior. Bright blue circles appeared around Beastman's wrists, stopping him in place as he roared.

"Get in the ship," Teela called, straining to hold Beastman with her magic. "Get ready to get us out of here.

Entrapta nodded, and she and Emily scurried into the ship. Beastman broke free of the magical restraints and turned toward Teela, eyes blazing and spittle dripping from his toothy maw. Teela readied a spell in one hand and her staff in the other, and Beastman charged.

=======

Catra led the way as she and Glimmer raced down the corridors, pausing at each intersection to scent the air for Melog and Wrong Hordak. They were getting close. Turning another corner, they found themselves outside a set of massive black metal doors. The scent trail stopped here.

"This is it," Catra said.

"Alright," Glimmer said. She took Catra's hand and teleported. But they were suddenly thrown to the floor. Glimmer felt like she'd run headlong into a wall.

"What happened?" Catra said, rubbing her head. "Why are we still in the hall?"

"There must be some kind of enchantment keeping anyone from teleporting in," Glimmer said. "Here, stand back."

Glimmer stepped in front of the doors and traced a large spell sigil in the air with both hands. With a grunt of effort, a blast of magical energy that shook the floor fired into the doors. The doors were thrown open, the metal dented and bent inward. As smoke and dust settled, Catra and Glimmer sprang into the room.

The chamber was large with a vaulted ceiling. A central walkway about twenty feet across stretched to the far end of the room. It was unclear how high up the walkway was, as beyond the sides of it, the room was shrouded in mist through which shone a dim green glow. Pillars rose from the fog to support the ceiling. At the far end of the room, a short flight of wide steps led up to a raised dais upon which sat a tall, narrow black throne. A hooded figure sat on the throne, a ram's-head staff clutched in one hand.

"Welcome," said a deep, raspy voice that managed to fill the room while still sounding like barely a whisper. "Though, I expected more than just two of you to find your way here." The figure looked up, revealing a yellow-white skull-like face beneath the purple cowl.

“You must be Skeletor,” Glimmer said. “We’re here for our friends. Release them, and we’ll leave in peace.”

“Will you now?” Skeletor chuckled. “And by what authority do you dare to command *me* ?”

“As Queen of Brightmoon,” Glimmer replied, walking forward, “and as leader of the Princess Alliance of Etheria and of the Great Rebellion that defeated the Galactic Horde.”

“So that old fool, Horde Prime has finally fallen, eh?” Skeletor rose from his throne and began walking down the steps. “His infinite pride finally caught up to him.”

Catra’s hand reflexively rubbed the back of her neck. This Skeletor guy was talking about Prime like he knew him personally. Not only that, but he talked like he thought Prime was...weak…
“Glimmer, be careful,” she whispered. “This guy’s more dangerous than he looks.”

“But where are my manners,” Skeletor said. “You asked for your friends.” He waved a hand, dismissing the illusion that had been concealing them. To the left of the stairs leading to the throne, a metal cage appeared. Inside, Wrong Hordak clutched the bars, tears leaking from his terrified eyes. Beside him Melog, its mane and eyes burning red, hissed and growled, thrashing at the bars. Each time it touched them, they flashed with a sickly green light, forcing it away.

“You may leave with them and your ship on one condition,” Skeletor said. “Leave Eternia and never return.”

“I don’t think so,” Glimmer said, scowling.

Skeletor sighed.

“Then so be it.”

He struck the floor with his staff, and tendrils of shadow raced across the floor toward Catra and Glimmer. Catra leaped back out

of the way, but Glimmer, forgetting about the room's enchantment, attempted to teleport away. She glowed and sparked, but remained in place, and that was all the time the tendrils needed to close the distance. They wrapped around Glimmer's legs and arms, holding her in place.

"Glimmer!" Catra called.

"Fools!" Skeletor cried, his voice now strong and manic. "You *dare* challenge me. I who have walked this galaxy since time immemorial! I who am the sole heir of the greatest empire in the history of the cosmos! I who am rightful master of the universe!"

He closed his fist, and the tendrils tightened on Glimmer's limbs, crackling pink light coursing from her, up the tendrils, and to him. He inhaled sharply as the energy reached him and coursed into his body.

"Your magic is quite potent, your highness," he crowed. "I will enjoy drinking it down."

Catra raced toward Skeletor, extending her claws, but she had to duck to the side as tendrils of shadow lashed out at her. Fortunately, Catra had plenty of experience avoiding this kind of dark magic. She ducked, dodged, and rolled, making her way closer to the skull-faced sorcerer with each step and leap. Each missed strike gouged the stone floor and columns like blades of darkness. Catra chanced a glance at Glimmer. She was still struggling against the tendrils, har magic slowly draining. *Just hold on a little longer,* Catra thought as she made way, avoiding Skeletor's attacks in a wide arc around him. Toward the left side of the room.

A shadow tendril slashed high at Catra, who nimbly leaped straight up and into a backflip...allowing the shadow to cleave through the top of the bars of the cage holding Wrong Hordak and Melog. The pale green magic illuminating the bars winked out.

Catra landed in front of the cage, grasping the bars and pulling down with all her might. They gave just enough, creating just enough space for the prisoners to squirm free.

Melog leaped through the opening to land at Catra's side. It mewled an apology for getting captured and offered to help Catra in the fight.

"No," Catra replied. "Got Wrong Hordak out of here and find Adora. I'll keep him busy and try to free Glimmer."

Melog was reluctant, but did as its friend asked. As Wrong Hordak clambored out of the cage, Melog scooped him up on its back and vanished from sight. Catra turned to face Skeletor.

"Fool," said Skeletor. "You should have run when you had the chance!" A flurry of tentacles lashed across the distance between them.

Catra leaped backward out of the way and onto the top of the cage. But she didn't feel her claws hit metal… Then something seized her ankle and yanked it out from under her. She hit the top of the cage hard and looked down at her foot. While she'd been focused on Skeletor's attacks, he'd extended shadows to snake up the sides of the cage. A trap, and Catra had jumped right into it. More tendrils slithered up to start wrapping themselves around her, lifting her in the air, covering her in chilling bands of shadow.

Skeletor laughed. "You all could have walked away with your lives, flown home and lived in peace. Now you must pay the price for your insolence!"

The shadows crept up over Catra's shoulders; up her neck.

"No!" Glimmer cried. "Catra!"

Catra strained against the cold enveloping shadows with all her might, but she couldn't budge it. Her claws found no purchase. Even as her head was wrapped in suffocating darkness, she could

hear Glimmer struggling and Skeletor laughing as if from underwater.

Catra couldn't breathe. Sounds grew distant. She was getting lightheaded. Her struggling limbs slowed…

Adora...

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Getting close to the end now.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Teela sidestepped again as Beastman charged. With a magical blast to the side of his face and a quick jab from her staff to the back of his knees, she sent him sprawling on the floor. Teela was out of breath. She hoped Entrapta was close to getting the ship ready for takeoff. She wasn't sure how much longer she could keep this up. Beastman pushed himself back to his feet. He growled, foaming spittle flying from his sharp teeth. He pounded the floor with his large fists and launched himself at Teela once more.

Inside the ship, Entrapta was working as quickly as she could to patch things back together. Whoever had been messing around with her systems was clearly an amateaur. At last, with one more pair of wires spliced back together, the interior lights flashed on and the ship hummed to life.

"Aha!" she cried. "Darla, are you there? Are you ok?"
"Welcome, Entrapta," Darla said.

"Did they hurt you?"

"I do not feel pain."

"Right. Get ready to launch in a hurry," Entrapta said. She turned to Emily. "Quick, go tell the not-Adora's-brother one it's time to go!"

Emily chirped and scuttled toward Darla's entry ramp.

Outside, Teela was in trouble. Beast man wasn't bright, but he wasn't completely stupid. Her bullfighting routine was never going to last forever. On this last charge, he'd suddenly lunged forward and grasped Teela's head in his huge clawed hand. Before she

could react, he'd thrown her hard. She tumbled across the floor and slammed into a wall, the wind knocked out of her. As Teela struggled to catch her breath, the Beastman loomed over her, eyes full of fury. He raised his fists high over his head and let out a roar.

There was a sudden crackling buzzing sound, and Beastman's face went slack. His arms dropped to his sides, and he fell forward onto his face. Teela looked past him to see the robot, Emily standing behind him, retracting a two-pronged metal rod back into her shell. The robot beeped and whistled, and started back toward the ship. Teela pulled herself to her feet and, leaning on her staff, made her way inside.

=======

Outside the fortress, Bow and Duncan still held off Skeletor's troopers, but they were losing ground.

"I'm running out of arrows here!" Bow cried.

"And I'm down to my last power cell," Duncan replied. "Whatever your friends are going to do, they'd better do it quick."

Suddenly, two creatures appeared beside the skiffs.

"Wrong Hordak!" Bow said.

"Brother!" Wrong Hordak replied, climbing into the skiff and embracing Bow.

"Where are Glimmer and Catra?"
"Still inside, fighting," Wrong Hordak explained. "They're in terrible danger!"

Melog had already bounded off in the direction where Adam and Adora were fighting.

“I have to go help them,” Bow said.

“You can’t, kid,” Duncan said. “I can’t hold off all these troopers alone. If they overrun us, we’ve got no way off Snake Mountain.” “But-”

“I’m sorry, but you have to trust that they can handle whatever mess they’re in.”

“Yes, brother,” Wrong Hordak said. “I’m sure Glimmer and Catra can handle that awful skeleton-man!”

“What?” Duncan cried. “We have to get in there, now! They can’t fight Skeletor on their own!”

=======

The rock monster lay in rubble at their feet. Adam and Adora were still fighting troopers and demolishing cannons. She felt herself tiring, and she could see the sweat standing on Adam’s brow. They couldn’t keep this up for much longer. She glanced again at the fortress, hoping to see some sign that it was time to go.

“There!” Adam shouted, pointing.

Adora followed where he’d indicated. Yes! Darla rocketed out from behind the fortress and soared over the battlefield. Adora looked to the skiffs at the base of the tower. She could make out...three figures. Bow and Duncan were there, and the third had pale white skin. Wrong Hordak! But where was…

Suddenly Melog appeared in front of Adora, mewling insistently. Why was…

"Oh no," Adora said. She turned and ran toward the fortress at full speed.

"Time to go?" Adam called, racing a few paces behind her.

"Catra and Glimmer are still inside," Adora said. "They didn't teleport out. Something's wrong!"

"Adora!" Bow cried as she approached the skiff. "Glimmer and-"

But Adora didn't wait for him to finish. Three heavy swings of her sword and a heel-kick later, there was a triangular hole in the outer wall of the fortress. Melog leaped through the opening, and Adora followed.

"Adora, wait!" Adam called. When she didn't so much as slow down, he growled in frustration and climbed in after her.

"Adam!" Duncan shouted. He moved to follow, but Bow stopped him with a hand on his chest.

"We can't," Bow said. "If we don't protect the skiffs, then *none* of us are getting out of here. It's like you said: we have to trust *them.* "

Duncan sighed, then turned his attention back to the oncoming troopers. Without He-Man and She-Ra drawing most of the fire, even more of them were coming. He looked down at his blaster. Empty. He holstered it, then flexed the fingers of his mechanical arm. His hand morphed into a double-sided axe blade.

"Then we hold them."

======

Glimmer struggled against the shadows that bound her arms and legs, but it was no use. Skeletor was laughing. Catra was trapped in a cocoon of darkness suspended above the floor. Could she breathe in there? On top of everything, Glimmer could feel Skeletor siphoning off her magic. It reminded her of the time Shadow Weaver had done the same…

She had an idea. Instead of fighting the pull on her power, she *pushed* into it. The waves of light coursing along the tendrils toward Skeletor pulsed faster, and he suddenly stopped laughing.

"What's the matter?" Glimmer taunted. "I thought you *liked* eating my magic. Here, have some MORE!"

Glimmer strained harder. Skeletor recoiled slightly, but he clenched his fist; the tendrils holding Glimmer tightened further. But Glimmer didn't relent. Her whole body began to glow as she forced herself to expel as much magic as she could as fast as she could. With a final cry of effort, energy and light exploded from Glimmer. The throne room shook, one of the pillars cracked, and the existing tentacles of darkness were burned away. As the light subsided, Glimmer saw that Skeletor had been thrown back against the stairs, and Catra lay on the floor, free of the shadows but not moving.

Glimmer breathed heavily. That had taken almost everything she had left. Whatever else happened, she couldn't let herself get ensnared in those tendrils again. She didn't have another move like that up her sleeve. She held one hand out to her side, hoping she had enough power left to...yes! Her father's staff materialized in her hand. She sprinted to Catra's side and knelt down to check on her. She was breathing. Good.

"Impudent wretch!" Skeletor growled, climbing back to his feet. "I will inflict unimaginable agony on you for this disrespect."

Glimmer stood defensively over Catra, staff at the ready.

“Sorry,” she said, “I don’t make a habit of giving respect to wannabe tyrants like you!”

“Tyranny is my *right* !” Skeletor shouted. “You think your She-Ra and He-Man are First Ones. Their degraded and degenerate kin are but a pale shadow of our former glory! A glory that *I* shall restore!”

“ *Your* former glory?”

“Yes,” Skeletor said. “When our kind faced extinction, I alone mastered the technologies and magics to preserve myself. Our ‘leaders’ called me mad, refused to do what needed to be done to survive Horde Prime. And now they are all gone. All except me. I am the last of the true First Ones.”

“You’ll never win,” Glimmer said. “People like you never do.”

“We shall see.”

With that Skeletor suddenly rushed toward Glimmer. She barely got her staff up in time to block the strike from his. He was much faster than Glimmer had expected. And stronger too. She pushed his staff away and countered with a strike of her own. Skeletor parried it, and so they continued, Glimmer trying desperately to keep up with the ferocious assault.

=======

Adora sprinted down the hallways just a few steps behind Melog. She could hear Adam racing along just behind her. Finally, they reached a set of great black metal doors that had looked like they'd been blasted open. Adora didn't pause. She sprinted straight through the door and quickly took in the room.

Vaulted ceilings. Pillars. Green mist. Glimmer fighting with her staff against a figure in purple robes. And-

Her heart sank into the pit of her stomach. Her blood turned to ice.

Catra, motionless on the floor.

Everything else fell away. Adora sprinted toward Catra as fast as she could, but it seemed to take too long, like she was running in water. Someone was shouting, but all she could hear was the pounding of her heart and her own heavy breathing. She dropped to her knees beside Catra and lifted her into her lap.

"Catra!" Adora cried.

She didn't respond. Panic clawed inside Adora's chest like a cornered animal. She felt something nudge her arm. Adora looked to see Melog, who meowed insistently. That grounded her just enough to finally notice the rise and fall of Catra's chest. Relief washed over Adora.

Catra was alive.

Adora looked over her shoulder and saw Adam and Glimmer were locked in combat with the purple-robed figure who must be Skeletor. Gently, Adora laid Catra back down on the floor and looked at Melog.

"Keep her safe," she said.

Melog yowled an acknowledgement and stood over Catra's unconscious form.

Adora rose to her feet, her sword reappearing in her hand, and charged into the fight.

Skeletor, seeing her coming, deflected blows from Glimmer and Adam with his staff, then slammed the staff against the floor. A wave of darkness blew both of them off their feet, and Skeletor met Adora's sword swing with his staff.

"She-Ra," Skeletor said mockingly, "I don't believe we've been properly introduced."

Adora responded only with another attack, which Skeletor also blocked.

Adam got to his feet and leaped back toward the fight with a heavy overhead swing of his sword. Skeletor deflected a blow from Adora, stepped away from her, and raised his free hand. Green lightning blasted Adam out of the air, who landed heavily beside Glimmer once more, his armor smoking.

Glimmer stood, watching Adora and Skeletor fight, looking for an opening. Then she noticed the web of shadows spreading out from Skeletor's feet.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried. "Look out for-"

Too late! The shadows suddenly leapt off the floor, constricting around Adora from every angle. Skeletor laughed and clenched his fist. Adora screamed as multicolored light coursed from her into Skeletor.

"I've never felt raw power such as yours before," Skeletor said. "I must thank you for bringing it to me."

Glimmer and Adam tried to rush at Skeletor, but he blasted them back down with another volley of green lightning. He continued to laugh, draining Adora's magic and holding Glimmer and Adam at bay with lightning.

Adora strained against the tendrils of darkness. She pulled with everything she had, but they wouldn't give. She wracked her brain, trying desperately to think of a way out. Suddenly, she felt a weight press down on her shoulders, then disappear just as abruptly. She looked up and saw nothing-

Catra appeared in midair, leaving the range of Melog’s invisibility field, claws extended. She raked them across Skeletor’s face, causing him to recoil. The lightning faltered, and the shadow tendrils slackened. Before he could react, Catra grabbed ahold of his cloak, planted her feet on his chest and kicked with all her strength. Caught off guard and off balance, Skeletor staggered

backward, one heel catching on the side of the walkway, and he tumbled over into the green mist, bellowing with rage.

"C'mon," Catra said, breathlessly. "I don't know how deep that is. We need to get out of here *now* !"

Adora helped Adam to his feet, and Catra helped Glimmer. As they made their way quickly out the ruined doors of Skeletor's throne room, they could hear the approaching footfalls of heavy boots.

"Everyone hold on," Glimmer said. She focused, pulling on the last of her reserves of magic. With great effort, she managed to teleport.

An instant later, Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Melog, and Adam appeared in the skiff outside, just as Bow fired his last arrow. Glimmer collapsed, unconscious.

"Glimmer!" Bow cried.

"She's ok," Catra said. "Just drained."

"Duncan, let's go!" Adam cried.

Without a word, Duncan seized the controls of the skiff, and it soared up and away from Snake Mountain. Adam and Adora changed back to their normal forms with heavy sighs of relief. Bow held Glimmer in his lap. Adora suddenly grabbed Catra in a tight embrace, her face buried in her shoulder.

"When I saw you, I thought… I thought…" Adora said, her voice catching in her throat.

"It's ok," Catra said, holding her and stroking her hair. "I'm ok."

Glimmer stirred.

"Did we make it?" she asked groggily.

"Yeah," Bow said. He kissed her forehead. "You made it."

“Good,” Glimmer sighed. “I wasn’t sure I had enough left to make it all the way out.”

“What happened in there?” Bow asked.

“A lot,” Catra said. “We should get back to the city and regroup with Teela and Entrapta. Then we can go over it.”

The skiff sailed through the sky over the desert, eventually crossing back into the green fields and forests around the city and castle.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading. One more chapter to wrap everything up. Thanks for coming on this journey with me.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Whew, that's better," said Glimmer, removing her hands from the runestone in Darla's cargo hold. "The one thing I *don't* like about exploring space is being able to run out of magic again."

They were back at Adam's castle. Everyone had shared what they'd experienced in the battle at Snake Mountain.

"Skeletor *has* to be lying," Bow said. "If he's really a First One, like a *real* First One, he'd have to be over *a thousand* years old!"

"He said he used magic and tech to keep himself alive since before their war with the Horde," Glimmer replied. "I don't know about his tech, but his magic is *incredibly* powerful." She hesitated. "Like stronger-than-my-dad powerful."

"Regardless," Adam chimed in, "it's more important than ever now that I make sure Skeletor never gets access to Castle Grayskull. If he *is* a First One, his first-hand knowledge of their technology might let him get to information even Adora and I can't."

Adora put a hand on her brother's shoulder.

"We won't let that happen," she said.

=======

The Etherians spent another dinner and overnight with the Royal Family. Adam and Adora swapped stories of their childhoods (Catra making sure to interject with particularly embarrassing episodes). Glimmer discussed ongoing relations between Eternia and Etheria. More than once, Catra had to jab Adora in the ribs with an elbow before she accidentally revealed Adam as He-Man to her parents. Entrapta worked through most of the night

inspecting Darla and setting up a portal beacon. There was no indication that Skeletor's minions had figured out enough about the ship while they had it to do any serious damage. Duncan provided a secure chamber within the castle for the installation of the beacon.

Eventually, late into the night, everyone made their way to bed or a night's sleep, and in the morning, it was time for the Etherians to go.

"Are you sure you don't want us to stay and help with the fight against Skeletor?" Adora asked her father. The others were milling around by the ship, giving Adora some privacy to say goodbye to her family.

"Thank you, but no," Randor said. "From what you've all told us, you all fought long and hard for your world's peace, and you deserve to enjoy it. I don't want to drag you into our war."

"Ok, but you'll call us on the beacon if things get too bad," she replied. "If you need us…if you need me…"

Randor laughed and hugged Adora.

"I promise. But as long as we have He-Man, I think we can handle things."

Adora hugged him again, then turned to her mother.

"It's so strange," Marleena said. "You've been gone so long, and we've only just gotten you back… I suppose I expected the thought of you leaving again would be unbearable." She took Adora's hands in hers. "But just knowing that you're safe, and happy…" she glanced over Adora's shoulder at Catra. Adora followed her gaze, also looking over her shoulder at Catra. She couldn't help but smile. "That's all we ever hoped for for you."

Adora hugged Marleena.

"I'm going to visit a lot," Adora said. "I promise."

"You'd better," Marleena said with a soft laugh. "We'll have a proper family dinner the next time you and Catra come to Eternia. You'll have to tell us all about how you two met and fell in love."

"Hoo boy, is *that* a long story…"

"I can't wait to hear it. I love you."

"I love you too, mom." Tears welled up in Adora's eyes.

They parted smiling, and Randor and Marleena stepped back inside the castle from the large balcony serving as their makeshift landing pad. That just left Adora and Adam. They gave each other a tight embrace.

"It's weird, you leaving so soon," Adam said.

"I know," Adora replied. "But I'll be back again soon, I promise."

"Can't wait." They released their hug, smiling warmly at each other. "And thanks, for everything."

"What are sisters for?" Adora shrugged. "And for real, if you need me-"

"I'll call," Adam interrupted. "I promise."

Adora walked toward the ship, looking back at her parents and brother the whole time. Adam started back into the castle. As Adora reached the entry ramp, Catra took her hand. Everyone else was already inside.

"Go on ahead," Catra said. " I'll catch up."

"Okay," Adora said.

Catra raised her hand to her lips and kissed her knuckles. As Adora entered the ship, Catra jogged across the landing pad.

"Adam," she called, "wait up!"

Adam stopped and turned back, letting Catra catch up to him.

“Hey, so,” she began, “this might sound a little weird…”

“What is it?” Adam asked.

“Could you… contact *me* on the beacon like a month before your birthday? We’ve always *had* a birthday celebration for Adora, but we were always just kind of guessing, of course. Now that we *can* know when her real birthday is, I’d… like to do something special for her. Y’know, for the first time we can celebrate her *real* birthday.”

“Will do,” Adam said with a smile.

“And… thank you…” Catra said. “For being good people, I mean. I’m really glad Adora found you.”

Awkwardly, Catra opened her arms toward Adam. He smiled and accepted the invitation for a hug.

“Take good care of my big sister, okay Catra?” Adam said.

“That’s the plan,” Catra replied.

With that Catra headed into the ship. Adora was waiting for her just inside.

“Aww,” Adora said. “Did you just give my brother a hug?”

“Oh shut up,” Catra groaned. “Don’t make a big deal about it.”

Adora just smiled.

Darla’s landing ramp closed, and the ship rose into the sky. Adam, Marleena, and Randor waving as it blasted off back into space.

=======

Skeletor stood on a balcony of his fortress. Below, his minions still toiled to clean up and repair from the previous day's battle. There had been much grovelling and begging for mercy. Skeletor had granted none, despite his greater designs.

"My lord," said Evil-lyn's voice behind him.

"Yes," he replied curtly.

She hesitated.

"They escaped," the question came more like a flat statement.

"It is of little consequence," Skeletor barked. "What of the mission I gave you?"

"Yes, my master. I found the Thenurian. He awaits you within."

Skeletor turned on his heel and marched into the fortress. He walked briskly through the maze of corridors to the room in question. A soldier fearfully unbolted and opened the metal door at his approach.

Inside lay a wide variety of scattered technology from different ages. Machines hummed, buzzed, and crackled. But the objects of Skeletor's interest were the newest additions. The first was a diminutive and terrified figure in chains. Pointed ears and nose stuck out from a mane of wild orange hair. The second was still within a wooden crate, the lid already removed and set aside.

Skeletor loomed over the Thenurian, relishing the panicked squeak and rattling chains as it cowered.

"Your reputation precedes you, locksmith," Skeletor whispered. He reached into the wooden crate to touch the device inside. The device he'd discretely removed from the strangers' vessel. "Tell me, Gwildor, what do you know about portals?"

Chapter End Notes

I'd like to thank all of you who took the time to read this story, and for all the kudos and comments that you've left. Writing this has been SO much fun. And we're not finished! I have an idea in mind for a full sequel as well as some fluffy interludes that didn't teally feel like they'd fit with the pacing of the rest of this story.

Can't wait to post more, and can't wait for you all to read it. Thanks again!

End Notes

Thanks for reading! I'm excited to get back into writing fanfics after a VERY long time (I'm fanfiction.net-years-old. Lol)
Anyway, I hope you liked it and come back when I post the next chapter. Thanks again!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!